RATIONALISM - DESCARTES, SPINOZA, LEIBNIZ

ONE DEFINITION AND THE DIAL → CHRONOLOGY → FIVE TENETS → METHOD AND DOUBT → THE THINKING SELF → IDEAS AND LOCKE → THE WAX → GOD, THE CIRCLE AND THE WORLD → DUALISM AND INTERACTION → ONE SUBSTANCE → NECESSITY AND PARALLELISM → KNOWLEDGE AND FREEDOM → MONADS → SUFFICIENT REASON AND HARMONY → RANKED VERDICT

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final synthesis. Each card uses a layout chosen for its own content; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

● PRIMARY CORE FLOW ● SUBORDINATE EXTRA ● APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00 ONE INHERITED DEFINITION AND THE DIAL THAT SPLITS THE SCHOOL

SUBSTANCE: IN ITSELF, CONCEIVED THROUGH ITSELF · DESCARTES 3 · SPINOZA 1 · LEIBNIZ INFINITELY MANY · WARRANT, NOT HOSTILITY TO THE SENSES · METHOD SHARED, ONTOLOGY NOT · MNEMONIC 3 - 1 - INFINITY · MIND-BODY I-P-H

LOOSE -> DESCARTES 3 -> interaction problem

STRICT -> SPINOZA 1 -> individuality problem → STRICT + SIMPLICITY -> LEIBNIZ infinity -> harmony bought in advance

THE PREMISE ALL THREE ACCEPT

- Experience may OCCASION a thought, but only intellect certifies necessity and universality. Rationalism is a claim about warrant, not a phobia about eyes.
- Necessary = could not be otherwise. Universal = all cases, not all observed cases. A priori = justified independently of any particular experience.

THE ONE DEFINITION, AND THE DIAL INSIDE IT

- Substance = that which exists in itself, is conceived through itself, and needs nothing else in order to exist.
- How strictly is 'needing nothing else' enforced? Descartes loosely and analogically (Principles I.51); Spinoza strictly; Leibniz strictly plus simplicity.

WHAT FOLLOWS IMMEDIATELY

- Three substances, one substance, infinitely many monads - and with them three theologies, three mind-body theories and three accounts of freedom.
- Memory chain: attribute separates, independence unifies, simplicity multiplies.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — A method fixes how to argue but not which criterion of the ontologically basic to enforce, so the divergence is rationalism working consistently rather than one of the three lapsing.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Rationalism is unified by confidence in a priori warrant and divided by the criterion of substance, which moves from Cartesian dualism through Spinozist monism to Leibnizian monadic pluralism.

01

STAGE 01 ONE ARGUMENT ACROSS EIGHTY YEARS - THE CHRONOLOGY THAT PREVENTS ANACHRONISM

DESCARTES 1596-1650 · SPINOZA 1632-1677 · LEIBNIZ 1646-1716 · ARNAULD 1641 - THE CIRCLE · ELISABETH 1643 - INTERACTION · LETTER 50, 2 JUNE 1674 · CANDIDE 1759 IS RECEPTION · RYLE 1949 IS NOT DESCARTES

1637 Discourse -> 1641 Meditations -> 1644 Principles -> 1649 Passions → 1656 excommunication -> 1670 Treatise -> 1674 Letter 50 -> 1677 Ethics → 1686 Discourse -> 1704 New Essays -> 1710 Theodicy -> 1714 Monadology

DESCARTES - THE TEXTS THAT CARRY THE DOCTRINE

- 1637 Discourse on the Method, Part II: the four rules. 1641 Meditations: I doubt, II the thinking self and the wax, III the trademark and conservation proofs, IV error, V the ontological proof, VI the real distinction and the external world.
- 1641 Objections and Replies: Arnauld states the Circle. 1643 letters with Princess Elisabeth of Bohemia. 1644 Principles I.7 and I.51. 1649 Passions of the Soul: the pineal gland.

SPINOZA AND LEIBNIZ - THE REPLIES

- Spinoza: excommunicated 1656; 1670 Theological-Political Treatise; 1674 Letter 50 to Jarig Jelles; 1677 Ethics, demonstrated in geometrical order, Parts I to V.
- Leibniz: 1686 Discourse on Metaphysics; 1704 New Essays against Locke; 1710 Theodicy; 1714 Monadology; 1715-16 Leibniz-Clarke correspondence.

WHY THE ORDER IS CAUSAL, NOT MERELY CALENDRICAL

- Spinoza's monism corrects an equivocation Descartes himself concedes; Leibniz's pluralism corrects Spinoza's absorption of individuals.
- Two cautions: the Ethics appeared only posthumously, so reaction to Spinozism often ran ahead of the text; and Leibniz's system must be assembled from four works together.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Read the trio as a single argument in which each successor tightens the predecessor's criterion, because that is exactly what the 2018 twenty-mark question asks you to explain.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The rationalists are not three biographies but one eighty-year argument in which each thinker reads his predecessor and enforces the same inherited definition more strictly.

02

STAGE 02 THE FIVE TENETS OF RATIONALISM AND WHAT THEY DO NOT CLAIM

INNATE COGNITIVE RESOURCES · REASON GROUNDS NECESSITY · INTUITION AND DEDUCTION · THE REAL IS THE RATIONAL · SUBSTANCE METAPHYSICS · DISPOSITIONAL, NOT KNOWN AT BIRTH · PYQ 2025 Q2(a) FIRST LIMB

TENET	CONTENT	THE PRECISION THAT SCORES
Innate cognitive resources	native capacities or structures of intellect, not copies of sensation	dispositional, never preformed conscious propositions
Reason grounds necessity	experience occasions; intellect warrants	the word is WARRANT, not source of ideas
Intuition and deduction	Descartes clear intuition and order; Spinoza geometrical order; Leibniz identities and sufficient reasons	naming three methods proves this is not a school summary
The real is the rational	the world's structure is accessible to reason	this is the tenet that licenses metaphysics at all
Substance metaphysics	reality explained by substance, attribute and mode	introduce it last, because it is what splits the school

THE PRECISION THAT EARNS THE MARK

- Say native CAPACITIES or dispositions, never truths known at birth, or Locke's universal-assent objection lands before the sentence ends.
- Say WARRANT rather than source of ideas; and name three different methods, because a school summary is what the examiner is trying to detect.

WHAT RATIONALISM IS NOT

- Not the claim that sensory beliefs are uniformly false; Descartes spends Meditation VI restoring the material world.
- Not the claim that the senses are useless; Spinoza classes sense-based imagination as a genuine, if inadequate, kind of knowledge.
- Not the claim that every truth is consciously present at birth.

WHY TENET FIVE COMES LAST

- Tenets one to four are shared without residue. Tenet five carries the inherited definition of substance, and that is where the school breaks apart.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The five tenets are the shared content and the substance question beneath them is the fracture line, so an answer that lists the tenets and stops has explained the agreement and not the disagreement.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Rationalism holds that some cognitive resources are native, that reason rather than sensation warrants necessity, that intuition and deduction reach an intelligible real, and that the real is to be articulated through substance, attribute and mode.

03

STAGE 03 CARTESIAN METHOD: FOUR RULES AND A THREE-STAGE DOUBT THAT DESTROYS ITSELF

FOUR RULES, DISCOURSE II · RULE 1 IS THE ENGINE · SENSE-DECEPTION · DREAM ARGUMENT · EVIL GENIUS (GENIUS MALIGNUS) · METHODIC - HYPERBOLIC - PROVISIONAL · THE LADDER BREAKS UNDER ITS OWN WEIGHT

EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> ORDER -> COMPLETE ENUMERATION → SENSES fall -> THE WORLD falls -> MATHEMATICS falls → and yet: to be deceived, I must EXIST to be deceived

THE FOUR RULES AND WHICH ONE DOES THE DAMAGE

- Evidence, analysis, order, complete enumeration. Rules two to four are intellectual hygiene borrowed from mathematical practice and by themselves remove no belief.
- Rule one is explosive: if assent is withheld from whatever is not evident, and a single counterexample makes a class non-evident, whole classes fall at once.

THE THREE STAGES, IN THEIR STRICT ORDER

- Sense-deception removes particular perceptual judgements; the immediate situation still seems safe.
- The dream argument removes the situation and the whole external world; extension, shape, quantity, number and mathematics survive.
- The evil genius removes even arithmetic; only what cannot be false while I am thinking it survives.

WHY THE ORDER IS ITSELF AN ARGUMENT

- Each stage attacks precisely what the previous stage left standing, so reporting the three doubts unordered destroys the escalation the examiner is testing.
- The doubt is methodic, hyperbolic and provisional: Descartes does not believe the world is absent.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The deceiver hypothesis defeats itself, because deception presupposes somebody deceived, and that is why the strongest possible doubt yields the one thing it cannot reach.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Cartesian doubt is not scepticism but scepticism turned into an instrument, pushed to the point of self-destruction on the single proposition it cannot touch.

04

STAGE 04 THE THINKING SELF: EXACT WORDING, EXACT STATUS AND EXACT LIMITS

I AM, I EXIST - MEDITATIONS II · COGITO ERGO SUM - PRINCIPLES I.7 · IMMEDIATE INTUITION, NOT A SYLLOGISM · PERFORMATIVE AND PRESENT-TENSE · THE ARCHIMEDEAN POINT · NOT YET AN ENDURING SUBSTANCE · LICHTENBERG AND HUME ATTACK HERE

WHAT IT ESTABLISHES

- That thinking is occurring and the thinker exists while thinking.
- That at least one proposition is immune to a supremely powerful deceiver, since the very supposition guarantees a subject to be deceived.

WHAT IT DOES NOT YET ESTABLISH

- Not an enduring immaterial substance, not diachronic personal identity, and not that the thinker is only a thinking thing.
- The real distinction is argued in Meditation VI, which is why Lichtenberg's 'there is thinking' and Hume's bundle critique both target the slide from an occurring thought to a substantial thinker.

WHY THIS IS A RATIONALIST FOUNDATION

- It is reached with no sensory premise, grasped by intellectual intuition, and it supplies the model from which the criterion of truth is read off.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Descartes explicitly denies a suppressed major premise such as whatever thinks exists, so the certainty is generated by the act of thinking and not by an inference from it.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The thinking self secures present thinking existence and nothing wider, which is why the strongest answers concede its narrowness before showing how Descartes argues for more.

05

STAGE 05 CRITERION, THE THREE KINDS OF IDEAS, AND INNATE IDEAS AGAINST LOCKE

CLEAR AND DISTINCT PERCEPTION · ADVENTITIOUS - FACTITIOUS - INNATE · OBJECTIVE AND FORMAL REALITY · ARGUMENT FROM INSUFFICIENCY · SEEDS OF KNOWLEDGE · LOCKE, ESSAY I · SENSATION AND REFLECTION · PYQ 2023 Q2(c)

THE CRITERION IS DERIVED, NOT ASSUMED

- Descartes asks what made the thinking self certain, finds nothing but clarity and distinctness, and generalises. Clear = present to an attentive mind; distinct = containing nothing unclear.
- The rule is extracted from one instance, so turning it into a general licence is exactly the work God is later asked to do - and where the Circle strikes.

WHY INNATE IDEAS ARE NEEDED

- The idea of the infinite cannot be built by extending or negating the finite, because I recognise myself as finite only by contrast with it.
- No sense-organ delivers a bearer persisting through changing qualities, and no number of measured figures yields must rather than so far.
- Innateness is therefore a CONSTITUTION, not a content: a disposition elicited on an appropriate occasion.

LOCKE'S TESTS AND THE ADJUDICATION

- No universal assent; nothing unknown can be in the mind; sensation AND REFLECTION suffice - omitting reflection misstates Locke.
- Verdict: occurrent innatism falls decisively; dispositional innatism stands but owes a criterion separating it from a bare capacity to learn.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Present the dispositional version of innateness first, because a 2023 answer that expounds the caricature and then reports Locke has staged a contest in which one side never got up.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Descartes reaches innate ideas by an argument from the insufficiency of sensation, and only the dispositional formulation of that doctrine survives Locke's attack.

06

STAGE 06 THE WAX ARGUMENT - THE MISSING HALF OF CERTAIN KNOWLEDGE

THE WAX (CERA) · INSPECTIO MENTIS · FLEXIBILE ET MUTABILE · HATS AND COATS · MIND IS NOTIOR · IT PROVES NO EXISTENCE · GASSENDI AND BERKELEY OBJECT

CLEAREST CASE -> FIRE DESTROYS THE CATALOGUE -> SAME WAX REMAINS → not sense (all replaced) -> not imagination (indefinite shapes) → -> INTELLECT: inspectio mentis -> and the MIND is better known

THE ARGUMENT IN EIGHT STEPS

- Take wax fresh from the honeycomb: taste, scent, colour, shape, size, hardness, coldness and a sound when rapped. Move it to the fire and every item is destroyed or replaced.
- Yet the same wax is judged to remain. So what is grasped is no item on the list; nor is it imagination, since heat gives indefinitely many shapes and no finite run of images exhausts them.
- Therefore intellect alone grasps an extended, flexible, changeable thing; and every such judgement discloses the judging mind, which survives even if the body does not.

WHAT THE ARGUMENT SILENTLY ASSUMES

- Identity through total qualitative replacement already presupposes a bearer distinct from the qualities, so Meditation II uses the metaphysics the Meditations claim to derive.
- It also assumes sense is exhausted by the catalogue, that imagination is image-bound, and that perception is self-intimating.

OBJECTIONS AND THE HONEST RESIDUE

- Gassendi in the Fifth Objections: extension is an abstraction from repeated experience. Reply: the empiricist must name the sensory item that registers identity, and there is none.
- Berkeley, Principles 9 to 11: extension without sensible qualities is unintelligible. Reply: extension is the mode of being of every quality that could be sensed - which presupposes what Berkeley denies.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The wax establishes how bodies would be known and never that any body exists, so the exclusion must be stated explicitly in any answer on the proof of the external world.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The wax turns a bare existential certainty into an epistemological priority claim: mind is the condition under which body can be known at all.

07

STAGE 07 GOD IN DESCARTES: THREE PROOFS, ONE CIRCLE AND THE EXTERNAL WORLD

TRADEMARK OR CAUSAL, MED. III · CONSERVATION, MED. III · ONTOLOGICAL, MED. V · DIVINE VERACITY · ARNAULD'S CIRCLE · MEMORY REPLY · PASSIVE FACULTY AND NATURAL INCLINATION · PYQ 2019 Q1(d)

THINKING SELF -> GOD -> WORLD (never reverse this order)

criterion proves God -> God certifies the criterion (the Circle) → reply: attended intuition needs no certificate; memory does

THREE PROOFS, THREE DIFFERENT QUESTIONS

- Trademark: the objective reality of the idea of the infinite needs a cause with adequate formal reality - where could this idea have come from?
- Conservation: I cannot sustain myself from moment to moment - what keeps me in existence?
- Ontological: existence belongs to the concept of a supremely perfect being - what does the concept itself contain? Kant's rider that existence is not a real predicate belongs to Topic 04.

THE CIRCLE, THE REPLY AND WHAT SURVIVES

- Arnauld in the Fourth Objections: clear and distinct perception proves God, and God then certifies clear and distinct perception.
- Reply: a perception actually before the mind compels assent; God secures only remembered perceptions and extended chains.
- Residual: the divine proofs are themselves extended arguments whose earlier premises are remembered, so the reply softens without removing the objection.

THE EXTERNAL WORLD IN FIVE STEPS

- Involuntary sensory ideas imply a passive faculty; a passive faculty needs an active cause; the cause is not myself; a great natural inclination refers them to bodies and no faculty corrects it; a non-deceiving God could not permit that error.
- Therefore material things exist as extended realities - but the proof secures body and extension far more securely than any particular colour, size or distance.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Whatever divine veracity underwrites - mathematics, memory, the external world and the conservation of created substances - inherits the vulnerability the Circle exposes.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: God is not an appendix to Cartesian epistemology but its load-bearing joint, which is why the Meditations stand or fall on Meditation III rather than Meditation II.

08

STAGE 08 CARTESIAN SUBSTANCE, THE REAL DISTINCTION AND THE INTERACTION GAP

RES COGITANS · RES EXTENSA · PRINCIPAL ATTRIBUTE AND MODES · REAL DISTINCTION, MED. VI · PRINCIPLES I.51 - ANALOGICAL · ELISABETH 1643 · PINEAL GLAND IS A LOCATION · UNION AS A PRIMITIVE NOTION

THE ARCHITECTURE

- God is infinite substance, absolutely independent, creating and continuously conserving. Thinking substance has thought as its principal attribute, with ideas and volitions as modes; extended substance has extension, with shape, size and motion as modes.
- The real distinction runs: I conceive each clearly without the other; whatever is clearly conceived apart God can create apart; therefore they are really distinct substances.

THE CONCESSION SPINOZA WILL EXPLOIT

- Principles I.51 concedes that only God needs nothing whatever, so created things need God and 'substance' is used ANALOGICALLY rather than univocally.
- This single concession is the hinge of the 2018 twenty-mark question and the reason Spinoza can claim to be the consistent Cartesian.

ERROR AND FREEDOM IN MEDITATION IV

- The will is infinite in scope and the intellect finite, so error is assent given beyond clear perception - a misuse of a perfect faculty, not a defect created by God.
- Freedom is the power to affirm, deny or withhold; and MERE INDIFFERENCE IS THE LOWEST GRADE, since the will assents most freely when moved by evident reason.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Princess Elisabeth's question of 1643 asks for a mechanism and the pineal gland supplies only a site, so calling the union a primitive notion preserves the phenomenon while abandoning the explanation.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Cartesian dualism is the criterion's own conclusion rather than a prejudice about souls, and the interaction problem is the bill that conclusion leaves behind.

09

STAGE 09 SPINOZA: ONE SUBSTANCE, ATTRIBUTES, MODES AND GOD OR NATURE

CAUSA SUI · DEUS SIVE NATURA · ATTRIBUTE EXPRESSES THE WHOLE ESSENCE · MODE: IN AND THROUGH ANOTHER · ETHICS I P15 - WHATEVER IS, IS IN GOD · ETHICS I P18 - IMMANENT, NOT TRANSITIVE · NATURA NATURANS / NATURATA · NOT AN ATHEIST

ONE ABSOLUTELY INFINITE SELF-CAUSED SUBSTANCE = DEUS SIVE NATURA

-> infinitely many ATTRIBUTES; we know THOUGHT and EXTENSION → -> infinite MODES -> finite MODES: this mind, this body

THE FOUR-STEP DEMONSTRATION

- Substance is what is in itself and conceived through itself. Two substances cannot share an attribute, since nothing would then distinguish them as substances.
- A finite substance would need limiting by another of the same nature, which the second step forbids; so substance is infinite. Therefore exactly one substance exists, possessing all attributes.

ATTRIBUTES AND MODES - THREE PRECISIONS

- Each attribute expresses the WHOLE essence, not a portion: Thought is not half of God. Attributes are not substances, and they are not parts.
- Modes come in two grades: infinite modes such as motion-and-rest and the infinite intellect, and finite modes determined by other finite modes in an endless series.
- The 'in' of P15 is ONTOLOGICAL, not spatial: it means existing as a determination of, and conceivable only through.

THE PANTHEISM VERDICT THE 2022 PAPER DEMANDS

- Yes in the precise sense that nothing exists outside God and all finite things are modes within one immanent substance.
- No in the crude sense: substance exceeds the two attributes we know, which is why panentheism has defenders and why Hegel's OPPOSITE charge of acosmism must be answered by insisting modes are real as expressions.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Spinoza refuses the analogical softening Descartes conceded, so dependent created substances become a contradiction in terms and the definition collapses of its own weight into a single infinite substance.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Spinoza is not attacking Descartes from outside but completing him from within, and the price of that consistency is that individuals become ways in which one thing exists.

10

STAGE 10 SPINOZA: NECESSITY, DETERMINATION AS NEGATION, AND PARALLELISM

ETHICS I P16 · ETHICS I P29 - NOTHING CONTINGENT · ETHICS II P7 - ONE ORDER · ETHICS II P13 - MIND IS THE IDEA OF THE BODY · LETTER 50, 1674 · HEGEL UNIVERSALISED THE SLOGAN · ACOSMISM IS THE OPPOSITE CHARGE · THE PROBLEM IS DISSOLVED, NOT SOLVED

NECESSITY, DERIVED NOT ASSERTED

- P16: infinitely many things in infinitely many ways follow from the necessity of the divine nature - an ontological inference, not a story in which God exists first and produces a world later.
- P29: contingency is a name for our ignorance of causes. P33: things could have been produced in no other way and no other order.
- God is free not by choosing otherwise but by being determined by nothing external, which is Definition 7 applied to the infinite.

DETERMINATION IS NEGATION - PROVENANCE FIRST

- The exact Latin slogan is NOT in the Ethics. Spinoza writes determinatio negatio est in Letter 50 to Jarig Jelles, 2 June 1674, and Hegel universalised it.
- For God: infinite, bounded by nothing, therefore pure affirmation. For modes: limited by other modes, therefore determinate and dependent. For knowing: see the finite through the affirmative whole, under the aspect of eternity.

PARALLELISM AND ITS HONEST COST

- II P7 makes the order of ideas the order of things and II P13 makes the mind the idea of the body, so a decision and a movement are one mode twice expressed.
- There is no cross-attribute causation, so the Cartesian problem stops arising - but ordinary mental causation is abandoned, and the two-parallel-trains image quietly reinstates two things.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Spinoza does not build a bridge between mind and body; he denies that there is a gap, because the premise that generated the gap was Descartes' plurality of substances.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Necessitarianism and parallelism are one doctrine seen from two sides, since a single necessary order must appear complete under each attribute and therefore needs no traffic between them.

11

STAGE 11 SPINOZA: THREE KINDS OF KNOWLEDGE, STRIVING AND ACHIEVED FREEDOM

IMAGINATIO / OPINIO · RATIO AND COMMON NOTIONS · SCIENTIA INTUITIVA · CONATUS - ETHICS III P6-P7 · ETHICS I DEF. 7 · THE CONSCIOUS STONE · AMOR DEI INTELLECTUALIS · VERUM INDEX SUI IS THE WEAK POINT

KIND	SOURCE	ADEQUACY AND STATUS
First - imaginatio / opinio	random experience through the senses; and from signs, hearsay, words, memory	inadequate, mutilated and confused; II P41 makes it the only cause of falsity
Second - ratio	common notions: what is equally in the part and in the whole	adequate and necessarily true
Third - scientia intuitiva	from an adequate idea of the formal essence of certain attributes of God to the essence of things	adequate, grasped in one act, the highest kind at V P25

THE FOURTH PROPORTIONAL - SPINOZA'S OWN EXAMPLE

- Given 1, 2 and 3, all three knowers reach 6. The merchant applies a remembered rule from signs; the mathematician demonstrates it from the common property of proportionals; the third sees the ratio in the essences themselves, in one act.
- Mnemonic: Merchant, Mathematician, Seer. The three kinds are three ONTOLOGICAL POSITIONS OF THE KNOWER, not three degrees of confidence.

HOW KNOWLEDGE BECOMES FREEDOM

- Bondage is being determined by causes external to my nature, which is the condition of one whose ideas are inadequate, since inadequate ideas are the traces of other bodies in mine.
- Adequate ideas ARE the mind acting from its own nature, so moving from the first kind to the second and third IS moving from bondage to freedom. Knowledge is not a means to freedom; it is freedom.
- Striving to persevere in being is a thing's actual essence; passive affects mark a partial cause, active affects an increase in the power of acting.

WHAT MUST BE CONCEDED

- Alternative possibilities never return, and even the achievement of freedom is itself necessitated.
- Intuitive knowledge is self-certifying by II P43, and self-certification is exactly what confident imagination also feels like - the strongest live objection to the epistemology.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Definition 7 contrasts freedom with external compulsion and never with causation, which is why adequate understanding increases freedom instead of diminishing it.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Spinoza does not abolish freedom but relocates it, from the will's indifference to the intellect's adequacy, so that the discovery that all is necessary is itself the act by which one becomes free.

12

STAGE 12 LEIBNIZ: MONADS, THE HIERARCHY AND GUARANTEED INDIVIDUALITY

SIMPLE, PARTLESS, INDESTRUCTIBLE · PERCEPTION IS NOT CONSCIOUSNESS · APPETITION · PETITES PERCEPTIONS · APPERCEPTION ONLY IN SPIRITS · MONADOLOGY 7 - NO WINDOWS · IDENTITY OF INDISCERNIBLES · PHAENOMENA BENE FUNDATA

EXTENSION divisible -> COMPOSITE -> aggregates presuppose SIMPLES

SIMPLE -> no shape, size or position -> only PERCEPTION + APPETITION → bare entelechies -> animal souls (memory) -> rational spirits

WHY THERE MUST BE SIMPLES

- Extension is divisible; whatever is divisible is composite; an aggregate derives its reality from its constituents; a heap of heaps with no grains anywhere is no heap.
- This also refutes Spinoza: if extension cannot be a possible essence of substance, Extension cannot be an attribute in his sense.
- A partless unit has no shape, size or position, so its only available states are representing and passing from one representation to the next.

THE HIERARCHY, AND WHERE GOD SITS

- Bare entelechies have only obscure minute perceptions; animal souls add memory and a consecutiveness resembling reason; rational spirits add apperception, necessary truths and moral community with God.
- God is the unique UNCREATED necessary simple substance. 'Supreme Monad' is common shorthand, not a place in the created series.

INDIVIDUALITY AND THE STATUS OF BODIES

- No two monads are exactly alike, because God would have had no sufficient reason to create indistinguishable duplicates - so individuality is GUARANTEED, which is precisely what Spinoza cannot deliver.
- An organism is a dominant monad with an organic aggregate; extended bodies are WELL-FOUNDED phenomena, grounded and therefore not illusions, non-ultimate and therefore not substances.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Windowlessness makes interaction impossible in principle, so the mind-body question can no longer be answered by influx and must be answered by a prior divine arrangement instead.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Monads are what remains once divisibility and causal influx are both denied, and Leibniz posits them to rescue the individuality that Spinozist monism dissolves.

13

STAGE 13 LEIBNIZ: SUFFICIENT REASON, TWO TRUTHS, POSSIBLE WORLDS AND HARMONY

PRINCIPLE OF SUFFICIENT REASON · TRUTHS OF REASON - FINITE ANALYSIS · TRUTHS OF FACT - INFINITE ANALYSIS · COMPLETE INDIVIDUAL CONCEPT · COMPOSSIBILITY AND THE BEST WORLD · INFLUENCE / ASSISTANCE / HARMONY · INCLINER SANS NECESSITER · CANDIDE 1759 IS SATIRE

PSR -> GOD | TWO TRUTHS | INDISCERNIBLES | THE BEST WORLD → COMPLETE CONCEPT -> certain, yet not absolutely necessary → HARMONY SET ONCE -> spontaneity + intelligence + contingency

FOUR CONSEQUENCES OF ONE PRINCIPLE

- God: the contingent series is itself contingent, so its sufficient reason must lie in a necessary being outside it.
- Two kinds of truth: the opposite of a truth of reason implies a contradiction and finite analysis reduces it to identities; the opposite of a truth of fact is conceivable and its analysis is infinite, completed only by God.
- Identity of indiscernibles; and the actualisation of the best world, meaning the greatest variety of phenomena under the simplest laws - never maximum human comfort.

THE NECESSITY DISTINCTION WHERE THE MARKS ARE

- Absolute or logical necessity applies only to truths of reason. Hypothetical or moral necessity means the series follows certainly given God's choice, while its opposite remains logically conceivable in another possible world.
- Without this distinction the complete individual concept makes every act necessary and Leibniz collapses into the necessitarianism he opposes.

HARMONY AND THE THREE CONDITIONS OF FREEDOM

- Leibniz himself lists three options: influence, which is Descartes' rod between the clocks; assistance, which is occasionalism and unworthy of a perfect craftsman; and harmony, set ONCE at creation.
- Freedom requires spontaneity, which windowlessness guarantees; intelligence, which distinguishes rational spirits from bare monads; and contingency, since the opposite of the act implies no contradiction.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Alternatives lie across possible worlds rather than within this one, so a libertarian will judge Leibnizian contingency epistemic and the honest verdict is coherent compatibilism rather than indeterministic freedom.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The doctrine that removes external influence is the same doctrine that makes every action self-expression, which is why a world in which nothing pushes anything is the world in which freedom is safest.

14

STAGE 14 SEVEN AXES, THE RESIDUAL LEDGER AND THE RANKED VERDICT

READ ACROSS THE ROWS · STATE THE CRITERION, THEN RANK · ECONOMY -> SPINOZA · FIDELITY TO EXPERIENCE -> DESCARTES · SYSTEMATIC CONSISTENCY -> LEIBNIZ · 2024 SAFE VERDICT: LEIBNIZ · FOURTEEN PYQ ROUTES, 2018-2025 · PROVENANCE EARNS MARKS

THE RESIDUAL COLUMN IS WHERE MARKS ARE EARNED

- Descartes: the Circle survives because the proofs use remembered premises; the pineal gland is a location and not a mechanism; the analogical use of 'substance' is the concession Spinoza exploits.
- Spinoza: acosmism is answered by modes real as expressions, yet dependent individuality stays thin; responsibility is reinterpreted, yet alternatives never return.
- Leibniz: harmony's defence is comparative rather than positive; the criterion of perfection is not independently testable; alternatives lie across worlds and not within this one.

RANK ONLY AFTER DECLARING A CRITERION

- If freedom requires alternative possibilities, Descartes wins at the price of an unintelligible interaction. If it requires self-determination, Spinoza wins at the price of free will itself.
- If it requires responsible agency under systematic determination, Leibniz wins - and that is the examiner-safe ruling for the 2024 comparative question, provided the criterion is stated first.

PROVENANCE AND CITATION DISCIPLINE

- Cite Spinoza structurally: I Def. 7, I P15, I P16, I P18, I P29, II P7, II P13, II P40 Scholium 2, V P32 Corollary. Structural references are translation-invariant.
- 'Determination is negation' is Letter 50 universalised by Hegel; 'the ghost in the machine' is Ryle in 1949; Candide is Voltaire's satire of 1759; 'monads have no windows' and 'incline without necessitating' are standard renderings.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — That no single criterion selects one answer is itself the strongest evidence that Descartes bequeathed a pseudo-problem rather than a problem, and it is why Empiricism opens by attacking innate resources.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The three rationalists are not three answers to one question but three verdicts on whether the question was well formed, so any ranking is only as good as the criterion it declares.

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EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT - ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH · THE CARTESIAN-CIRCLE LITERATURE · SPINOZA'S ATTRIBUTES PROBLEM · CONTINGENCY BY INFINITE ANALYSIS · PANTHEISM VERSUS PANENTHEISM · ANALOGICAL PREDICATION OF SUBSTANCE

INTERPRETIVE DISPUTES

- Does Descartes need divine veracity before trusting clear and distinct perception at all, or only across memory and extended reasoning? The vicious-circle, memory-guarantee and self-certifying readings divide here.
- If substance has infinitely many attributes but we know two, what is an attribute? Epistemic-limitation, expressive and stricter conceptual readings compete, and each answers the charge that unknown attributes are ornamental.

SECOND-ORDER PRESSURE POINTS

- Necessary truths terminate in identities through a finite analysis while contingent truths require an infinite analysis only God completes - which preserves contingency but can make it look merely epistemic from the creature's standpoint.
- Is Descartes' analogical use of 'substance' a controlled scholastic analogy or an equivocation that empties the definition? The answer decides whether Spinoza is his corrector or his opponent.

LABELS AND ONE-LINE COMPARISONS

- Pantheist, panentheist and acosmist are three different claims, and only the first two are labels for Spinoza's theism at all.
- Later owners - Locke, Berkeley, Hume, Kant - may be named in a clause as the destination of the substance question, never developed here.

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

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